Candidate Experience Journey

TALENT ACQUISITION · CANDIDATE COMMUNICATION

Self-initiated portfolio project. The journey, templates and recommendations are proposed examples—not based on real employer data or measured outcomes.

1. Objective and design principles

Design a clear, respectful and predictable candidate experience from application through pre-joining hand-off. The journey focuses on the information candidates need, clear ownership, realistic timelines, and communication that preserves dignity and privacy.

- Be timely and transparent without promising decisions before they are confirmed.
- Provide useful logistics in one place and make a contact route visible.
- Use consistent, job-related assessment criteria.
- Handle candidate information only through approved channels and with appropriate access controls.

2. Candidate journey map

Stage	Candidate need	HR touchpoint	Potential friction	Improvement opportunity
Application	Was my application received? What happens next?	Acknowledgement and process overview	No confirmation; unclear timeline	Confirm receipt, explain the next step and set a realistic update expectation.
Screening	Is my application being reviewed?	Status update when appropriate	Long silence or vague expectations	Communicate review timelines and update candidates if they change.
Recruiter conversation	What should I prepare?	Scheduling and preparation note	Unclear duration, format or participants	Share agenda, duration, format, interviewer role and contact for access needs.
Interview	What will be assessed and where do I join?	Interview invitation and reminder	Missing logistics or inconsistent evaluation	Use a consistent invite template and structured, role-relevant evaluation criteria.
Decision / delay	When should I expect an update?	Progress update or revised timeline	Missed promises and no status update	Send a short delay update even if a final decision is not ready.

Offer / outcome	What is the decision and what happens next?	Offer conversation or respectful outcome note	Ambiguous next steps or impersonal communication	Communicate the outcome clearly, respectfully and with the next step where relevant.
Pre-joining hand-off	Who will contact me before joining?	Confirmed next steps and joining contact	Recruitment-to-onboarding hand-off gap	With appropriate consent and data handling, introduce the onboarding contact and confirm logistics.

3. Touchpoint ownership matrix

Touchpoint	Primary owner	Service standard to define	Evidence to monitor
Application acknowledgement	Recruiting coordinator / ATS	Target acknowledgement time	Timestamp or system event
Interview scheduling	Recruiter / coordinator	Response time and rescheduling process	Time to schedule; reschedule count
Candidate updates	Recruiter	Update cadence and escalation owner	Time since last update
Interview feedback	Interviewers + recruiter	Feedback submission target	Feedback completion time
Outcome communication	Recruiter / hiring team	Decision communication target	Time from decision to candidate update
Pre-joining hand-off	Recruiter + onboarding contact	When contact and logistics are shared	Handoff completion and candidate questions

4. Sample communication templates

A. Application acknowledgement

Subject: Application received — [Role Title]

Hello [Candidate Name],

Thank you for applying for the [Role Title] position. Your application has been received. The team will review applications against the role requirements, and we will share an update when the next step is confirmed. We appreciate your interest in [Organisation].

Regards,
[Recruiter Name]

B. Interview invitation

Subject: Interview invitation — [Role Title]

Hello [Candidate Name],

We would like to invite you to interview for the [Role Title] position.

Date and time: [Date, time and time zone]
Format / location: [Video link or address]
Duration: [Duration]
Interviewers: [Names or roles, if appropriate]
Preparation: [Relevant instructions]

Please let us know whether this time works for you or if you need an adjustment. We will share any changes as early as possible.

Regards,
[Recruiter Name]

C. Process delay update

Subject: Update on your application — [Role Title]

Hello [Candidate Name],

Thank you for your patience. The selection process is taking longer than anticipated, and we do not yet have a final update. We expect to share the next update by [Date]. We will contact you sooner if there is a change.

We appreciate the time you have invested in the process.

Regards,
[Recruiter Name]

D. Respectful outcome message

Subject: Update on your application — [Role Title]

Hello [Candidate Name],

Thank you for meeting with us and for your interest in the [Role Title] position. After careful consideration, we will not be moving forward with your application for this role. We appreciate the time and preparation you invested and wish you the best in your search.

Regards,
[Recruiter Name]

E. Pre-joining hand-off

Subject: Next steps before your start date — [Role Title]

Hello [Candidate Name],

We are pleased to confirm the next steps before your planned start date of [Date]. [Onboarding Contact / Team] will coordinate the joining process and share the information you need for your first day.

Please use [approved contact channel] if you have questions or need to discuss an adjustment. Any required documents should be shared only through the organisation's approved secure process.

Regards,
[Recruiter Name]

5. Metrics to consider

- **Update reliability:** Share of candidates updated by the date they were promised.
- **Time in stage:** Elapsed time between defined process stages; interpret alongside role type and calendar delays.
- **Scheduling friction:** Reschedules and time to confirm interviews, with reasons categorised consistently.
- **Candidate feedback:** Optional short survey on clarity, respect, logistics and communication.
- **Withdrawal / offer outcomes:** Review withdrawals and offer decisions with context; do not assume communication alone explains them.

6. Prioritised recommendations

1. Set realistic response-time expectations and update candidates when timelines change.
2. Standardise interview invitations so candidates receive format, duration, participants and preparation details in one place.
3. Assign a clear owner to each candidate communication stage and define a hand-off process.
4. Use consistent, job-related evaluation criteria and encourage timely interviewer feedback.
5. Collect voluntary candidate feedback where appropriate and treat friction points as hypotheses until evidence validates them.

7. Limitations and validation plan

No real candidate feedback or employer data was available for this exercise. The friction points are hypotheses to validate. A next iteration could review the templates with recruiters, gather anonymised and voluntary candidate feedback where appropriate, and compare process indicators before and after any approved change. Any comparison should account for role mix, hiring volume, market conditions and process changes.

8. Project evidence and scope

Completed deliverable: a proposed journey map, touchpoint ownership matrix, five reusable communication templates, metric definitions and an improvement plan. This is a self-initiated design exercise; it does not claim implementation or measured business impact.